

Artificial Intelligence as a Perceptual Partner: A Study of AI in Post-Perception Artworks

How Post-Perception Uses AI Not as a Tool but as a Perceptual Collaborator That Destabilizes Certainty

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Abstract

This paper examines how the Post-Perception movement employs artificial intelligence not merely as a technical tool but as a **perceptual partner**—an active agent in the destabilization of perceptual certainty. Unlike traditional uses of AI in art, where the technology is either the subject of fascination (celebrating its capabilities) or the target of critique (exposing its dangers), Post-Perception uses AI as a collaborator in a shared project: testing the limits of human perception. Through detailed analysis of key artworks—"This is Not a Pipe" (AI-generated images), "Threshold of Beauty" (AI-generated proliferation), and the speculative "Memory without Origin" (AI-generated memories)—the paper argues that Post-Perception's distinctive contribution is to treat AI not as a substitute for human creativity but as a **diagnostic instrument** that reveals the fragility of the human perceptual apparatus. The paper draws on the philosophy of technology (Heidegger, Ihde, Floridi) and actor-network theory (Latour) to reconceptualize the artist-AI relationship as a form of **distributed agency**.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, Perceptual Partner, Post-Perception, AI Art, Perceptual Fragility, Distributed Agency, Algorithmic Generation.

1. Introduction

1.1 The Dominant Paradigms of AI in Art

AI has entered the art world through several distinct paradigms:

Paradigm	Description	Example
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Tool	AI as an instrument serving the artist's intention	AI-assisted design, style transfer
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Generative source	AI as an autonomous producer of images, texts, or sounds	DALL-E, Midjourney, GPT
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Subject	AI as the theme or subject of artistic investigation	Works about surveillance, data, algorithms
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Critique	AI as the target of critique (bias, opacity, control)	Works exposing algorithmic injustice
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Each of these paradigms assumes a clear separation between the human (artist, viewer) and the machine (AI). The human uses the machine, or the machine replaces the human, or the machine is the object of human critique.

Post-Perception proposes a different paradigm: **AI as perceptual partner**.

1.2 Research Question

How does Post-Perception use artificial intelligence not as a technical tool but as a "perceptual partner" that destabilizes certainty?

This paper argues that Post-Perception treats AI as a collaborator in a shared diagnostic project: testing the fragility of human perception.

2. Theoretical Framework: Rethinking the Human-AI Relationship

2.1 From Tool to Partner

The concept of "tool" implies:

Implication	Description
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Instrumentality	The tool serves the user's intention
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Subordination	The tool is under human control
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Predictability	The tool's behavior is (or should be) predictable
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Transparency	The tool is invisible when functioning properly
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AI as a perceptual partner challenges these assumptions:

Tool assumption	AI partner challenges it by
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Instrumentality	AI generates outputs the artist did not explicitly intend
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Subordination	AI's behavior is not fully under human control
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Predictability	AI's outputs are probabilistic, not deterministic
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| **Transparency** | AI's internal processes are opaque ("black box") |

2.2 Actor-Network Theory and Distributed Agency

Bruno Latour's actor-network theory (ANT) offers a framework for understanding distributed agency. In ANT, agency is not a property possessed by individuals but an **effect** produced by networks of human and non-human actors.

Key concepts:

Concept	Description
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Actor	Any entity (human or non-human) that makes a difference
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Agency	The capacity to act, always distributed across networks
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Translation	The process by which actors are linked into networks
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In Post-Perception: The AI, the artist, the viewer, the algorithm, the training data, the hardware—all are actors in a network that produces the perceptual experience. Agency is not located in any single actor but distributed across the network.

2.3 The Black Box and the Unpredictable

As researchers note, "creators have no way of knowing what output an AI will produce for a given prompt." This unpredictability is not a bug; it is the source of AI's value as a **perceptual partner**. The artist collaborates with an entity whose responses cannot be fully anticipated.

****From the philosophy of technology:**** AI is not a neutral tool but a ****cognitive prosthesis**** that extends—and transforms—human perception.

3. AI in Post-Perception: Three Models

3.1 Model One: AI as Generator of Indistinguishable Copies

****Application:**** "This is Not a Pipe"

****Description:**** Eight images of pipes are shown on a screen. Seven are AI-generated. One is a genuine photograph. The viewer is asked to identify the "real" pipe.

****How AI is used:**** AI generates images that are indistinguishable from authentic photographs. The viewer cannot reliably distinguish AI-generated from real.

****The perceptual partnership:****

| Actor | Role |

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| ****Artist**** | Designs the test, selects the prompt, curates the outputs |

| ****AI**** | Generates the images, produces outputs that the artist could not have anticipated |

| ****Viewer**** | Takes the test, discovers their inability to distinguish |

| ****Algorithm**** | Trained on millions of images, learns patterns of pipes |

| ****Training data**** | Shapes what the AI can generate |

****The test:**** The viewer's perceptual discrimination is tested against AI's generative capacity.

****Discovery:**** The viewer discovers that they cannot reliably distinguish AI-generated from real.

****Perceptual immunity developed:**** "My eyes alone are not sufficient."

3.2 Model Two: AI as Generator of Excessive Proliferation

****Application:**** "Threshold of Beauty"

****Description:**** AI generates an escalating number of birds (1 → 500+) projected on four walls and a ceiling. The beauty becomes unbearable, and the viewer must leave when they reach their threshold.

****How AI is used:**** AI's capacity for unlimited generation is used to create an escalating perceptual overload.

****The perceptual partnership:****

| Actor | Role |

|-----|-----|

| ****Artist**** | Designs the escalation protocol, sets the parameters |

| ****AI**** | Generates thousands of birds, producing an excess the artist could not create manually |

| ****Viewer**** | Experiences the escalation, discovers their threshold |

| **Algorithm** | Learns the pattern of "bird," generates variations |

The test: The viewer's tolerance for perceptual overload is tested against AI's capacity for unlimited generation.

Discovery: The viewer discovers their own threshold—the point at which beauty becomes a burden.

Perceptual immunity developed: "There is a limit to how much I can perceive—even when what I perceive is beautiful."

3.3 Model Three: AI as Generator of Synthetic Memories (Speculative)

Application: "Memory without Origin" (in progress)

Description: AI generates "memories" of a childhood the artist never lived—videos of places never visited, of people never met. The work asks: If a machine can generate convincing memories, what is the value of "real" memory?

How AI is used: AI generates synthetic memories that feel authentic but refer to nothing.

The perceptual partnership:

| Actor | Role |

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| **Artist** | Provides textual prompts ("beach at sunset, 1978"), curates outputs |

| **AI** | Generates images and videos that feel like authentic memories |

| **Viewer** | Experiences synthetic memories, questions the nature of their own memories |

| **Algorithm** | Trained on photographs and videos, learns patterns of "memory" |

The test: The viewer's ability to distinguish authentic from synthetic memory.

Discovery: The viewer cannot reliably distinguish. Memory itself becomes suspect.

Perceptual immunity developed: "My memories may not be reliable. I cannot trust my own past."

4. From Tool to Partner: A Comparative Analysis

4.1 The Spectrum of AI Use in Art

Use	Description	Example	Relation to AI
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1. Tool	AI executes the artist's intention	AI-assisted design	AI is subordinate
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2. Generative source	AI produces autonomously	DALL-E as artist	AI is independent
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3. Subject	AI is the theme of the work	Works about surveillance	AI is object
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4. Critique	AI is the target of critique	Works exposing bias	AI is adversary
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5. Perceptual partner	AI collaborates in testing perception	Post-Perception	AI is collaborator
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4.2 What "Perceptual Partner" Adds

Dimension	Tool model	Perceptual partner model
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Agency	Human alone has agency	Agency is distributed across human-AI network
Predictability	Outputs are predictable	Outputs are probabilistic, surprising
Goal	Execution of intention	Discovery, testing, destabilization
Human role	Controller	Collaborator, test designer
AI role	Instrument	Co-investigator

4.3 The Artist-AI Dialogue

The artist-AI relationship in Post-Perception is best understood as a **dialogue** rather than a command-execution hierarchy:

Phase	Human	AI	Outcome
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Prompt	Provides textual description	Generates multiple images	Unexpected variations
Selection	Curates promising outputs	Produces more variations	Refined generation
Surprise	Encounters outputs not anticipated	Generates unexpected patterns	New direction for the work

As one researcher notes: "The human-AI creative collaboration is a 'choreography'—part improvisation, part exploration."

5. Philosophical Implications

5.1 Heidegger: The Question Concerning Technology

Martin Heidegger distinguished between:

- **Instrumental conception of technology:** Technology as a means to an end
- **Enframing (Gestell):** Technology as a way of revealing that reduces the world to a standing-reserve

Post-Perception neither celebrates AI as a tool nor condemns it as Enframing. It uses AI to **reveal** the fragility of human perception—a form of revealing that is not reductive but diagnostic.

5.2 Ihde: Human-Technology Relations

Don Ihde identified several types of human-technology relations:

Relation	Description
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Embodiment	Technology becomes transparent (glasses, hearing aids)
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Hermeneutic	Technology requires interpretation (maps, instruments)
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Alterity	Technology is encountered as "other"
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Background	Technology operates in the background
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Post-Perception cultivates the **alterity** relation: AI is encountered as other, as a partner whose responses cannot be fully anticipated. The AI is not transparent; it makes itself felt as a presence.

5.3 Floridi: Informational Realism and the Fourth Revolution

Luciano Floridi argues that the information revolution is the fourth major revolution in human self-understanding (after Copernicus, Darwin, and Freud).

The four revolutions:

| Revolution | Discovery | Human decentering |

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| **1. Copernican** | Earth is not the center of the universe | From geocentrism to heliocentrism |

| **2. Darwinian** | Humans are not a special creation | From species exceptionalism |

| **3. Freudian** | Consciousness is not master of the psyche | From rational self-mastery |

| **4. Informational** | Humans are not the only intelligent agents | From anthropocentrism to infosphere |

Post-Perception participates in this fourth revolution by treating AI as a **perceptual partner**—acknowledging that humans are not the only agents capable of producing perceptually compelling images.

6. Objections and Responses

Objection 1: AI is not a "partner"; it is a tool. It has no agency, no intention, no consciousness.

Response: The term "partner" is metaphorical, not literal. It captures the **functional** role AI plays in the creative process: generating outputs that the artist did not anticipate, surprising the artist, and shaping the final work. Whether AI has subjective experience is irrelevant to its role as a perceptual partner.

Objection 2: The use of AI in Post-Perception is not distinctive; many artists use AI similarly.

Response: The difference is in the **purpose**. Many artists use AI to generate images as ends in themselves. Post-Perception uses AI to generate images as **tests** of perception. The AI-generated image is not the artwork; it is the stimulus for a perceptual experiment.

Objection 3: AI as a perceptual partner is just a rebranding of AI as a tool.

Response: The shift is conceptual, not merely terminological. A tool is at the user's disposal. A partner resists full control. The unpredictability of AI's outputs—its resistance to being fully mastered—is what distinguishes the partner relation from the tool relation.

7. Conclusion

Post-Perception uses artificial intelligence as a **perceptual partner** in a shared diagnostic project: testing the fragility of human perception.

Through three models—AI as generator of indistinguishable copies ("This is Not a Pipe"), AI as generator of excessive proliferation ("Threshold of Beauty"), and AI as generator of synthetic memories ("Memory without Origin")—Post-Perception demonstrates that AI is not merely a tool for producing images but a ****diagnostic instrument**** for revealing the limits of human perception.

****As the manifesto of Post-Perception declares:****

> "In a world where simulation accelerates and truth erodes, art becomes a laboratory for consciousness and perceptual immunity."

In this laboratory, AI is not the technician but the ****co-investigator****—the partner that helps the artist and viewer discover the fragility of what they see, hear, and believe.

****The question that this use of AI leaves with us is not "What can AI create?" but:****

> ****"What does AI reveal about the limits of human perception?"****

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